

LIFE-GIVING LIQUID

BLOOD DONATION

Like skin and bone, blood is a tissue—a collection of specialized cells. Blood carries oxygen and carbon dioxide around the body, transports other important nutrients, and helps keep our bodies at the right temperature. It also contains white blood cells, which fight off infections and produce antibodies to protect us (see page 122). If blood is lost during surgery, or more is needed to treat a medical condition, it can be provided by a blood donor.

BLOOD TESTS

Blood tests are an important part of medicine. They are used to measure the amount of substances in the body, such as salts, fats, and sugars. The results tell doctors how well a person's kidneys, liver, and other organs are working.



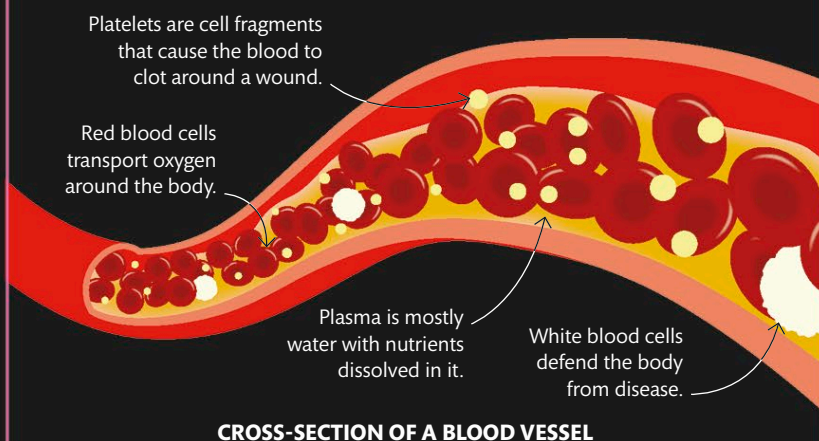
Donating blood

Blood is essential for the healthy working of the human body. If blood is lost, a person's life can be saved by giving them a blood transfusion—pumping someone else's blood into their body. This is made possible by volunteers donating blood, which is then sent to hospitals where it is needed. Over time, the donor's body is able to replace the blood given.



BLOOD

Blood is made up of different kinds of cell floating in a watery liquid called plasma. Pumped by the heart, it travels around the human body in tiny tubes called blood vessels. There are three types of cells—red, white, and platelets—and each one does a different job.



Blood makes up about 8 percent of the weight of an adult human's body.